Some of these places were towns of importance but there were many caravan-serais along the way although their quality varied a great deal. The larger caravan-serais had spacious walled enclosures where merchants could spend the night in safety. Travellers would have been able to draw water from the wells and buy provisions. In addition, many of the busy roads would have had water-stops or ‘piyaus’. The provision of drinking water to a thirsty traveller was said to gain religious merit (*punya*) and people built piyaus in memory of loved ones. Many of these have survived to modern times (indeed, new ones are still being built). The road from Delhi to Gurgaon (MG Road) used to have several old piyaus till recently. The last one was demolished in 2009 to make way for the new Metro line.

Of course, the quality of the road and accommodation could sometimes be appalling, especially on the less-frequented routes. The Portuguese Catholic priest Friar Sebastian Manrique has left us a most amusing anecdote of his travels through Orissa and Bengal during the monsoon of 1640[18]. After leaving the town of Jalesar, the priest and his companions found themselves in a small village which did not have a proper caravanserai. They were, therefore, obliged to spend the night in a large cowshed. The bovine occupants of the shed were the least of their problems for they were attacked by a swarm of mosquitoes. When they thought that matters could get no worse, it began to rain and they discovered that the roof leaked.

It was almost dawn when Sebastian Manrique was finally able to doze off but the peace did not last. The cowshed was suddenly full of birds including two large peacocks. The friar’s companions decided to kill and eat the peacocks. They were aware that the locals regarded the birds as sacred and tried to hide their activities. Unfortunately, the truth was discovered by their hosts and very soon an armed mob gathered outside. The friar’s party hurriedly fled, firing muskets to cover their retreat. Such was the experience of life on the road in seventeenth-century India.